GOGO'S RECIPE

Written by

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Self-written sample screenplay for Panelwise.
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FADE IN:

INT. SMALL FLAT - KITCHEN - MORNING

A narrow kitchen. A two-plate stove, a sink full of dishes, a calendar from a butchery on the wall.

ZODWA (30s), work blouse, hair wrapped in a scarf, flips through a battered exercise book. Its pages are stained with oil and covered in faded blue handwriting.

Her son, MPHO (10), sits on the counter swinging his legs and eating dry cereal from the box.

MPHO
You can't cook, Ma.

ZODWA
I can cook. I just don't.

MPHO
Gogo's birthday is tomorrow. She'll know if it's wrong.

ZODWA
(reading)
"Dombolo. Flour. A little yeast. Sugar, not too much. Water, warm like a baby's bath." Like a baby's bath! How warm is that?

MPHO
Use your elbow. That's what Gogo does.

Zodwa stares at him. Then she rolls up her sleeve.

INT. SMALL FLAT - KITCHEN - LATER

Flour everywhere: on the counter, on the floor, on Mpho's nose. A big steel bowl sits on the counter under a tea towel.

Zodwa lifts the corner of the towel. The dough lies flat. It has not risen at all.

ZODWA
It's dead.

MPHO
Maybe it's sleeping.

Zodwa grabs her phone and dials. She puts it on speaker.

AUNT LINDIWE (V.O.)
(on the phone)
Hello? Zodwa? Is everything all right?

ZODWA
Aunt Lindiwe. Gogo's dombolo. What's the secret?

AUNT LINDIWE (V.O.)
There's no secret. You just do it the way she does it.

ZODWA
That's the secret!

INT. SMALL FLAT - KITCHEN - AFTERNOON

The kitchen is clean again. Three bowls of dough sit in a row, each under a tea towel, each with a paper label: ONE, TWO, THREE.

Mpho holds the exercise book. He turns it upside down and squints at the back cover.

MPHO
Ma. There's writing at the back. Tiny writing.

Zodwa takes the book. On the inside of the back cover, in pencil, a single line.

ZODWA
(reading slowly)
"Put it by the window where the sun comes in. And sing to it. It likes a hymn."

MPHO
Sing to the bread?

ZODWA
Your great-grandmother sang to the bread. Your Gogo sang to the bread.

She carries a bowl to the window. The afternoon sun falls across it.

ZODWA
(clearing her throat)
Fine. Fine.

She starts to sing, badly. Mpho covers his ears. Then he joins in, worse.

INT. SMALL FLAT - KITCHEN - EVENING

The tea towel on bowl ONE has lifted into a dome. Zodwa peels it back. The dough has doubled, round and smooth.

Mpho gasps. Zodwa covers her mouth with her floury hand.

INT. GOGO'S HOUSE - DINING ROOM - DAY

A crowded table: a birthday cake with too many candles, a pot of chicken stew, and a big plate of round, fluffy DOMBOLO.

GOGO (80s), purple church hat, sits at the head of the table. Family squeezes in around her. She tears a dumpling in half and tastes it. The whole table waits.

GOGO
Who made this?

ZODWA
Me. Mpho helped.

GOGO
What did you sing to it?

MPHO
A hymn.

Gogo nods slowly, chewing. Then she smiles.

GOGO
Next time, sing in tune.

Everyone laughs. Zodwa hugs Mpho, leaving a floury handprint on his shirt.

FADE OUT.